

What shall I do with my time?

Ten free hours



A paper

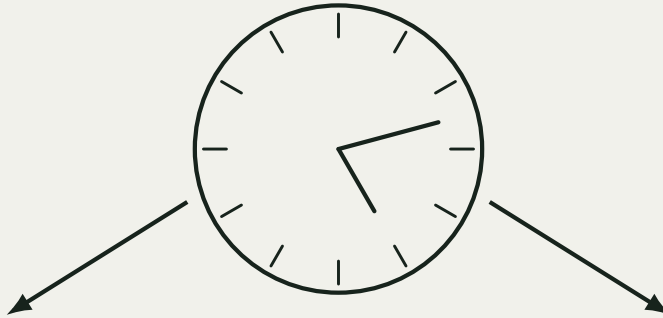


Something new

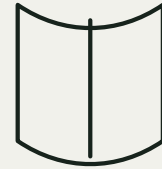


Teaching, meetings,
and admin are done.
How do I use the
hours left?

The same hour has two uses.



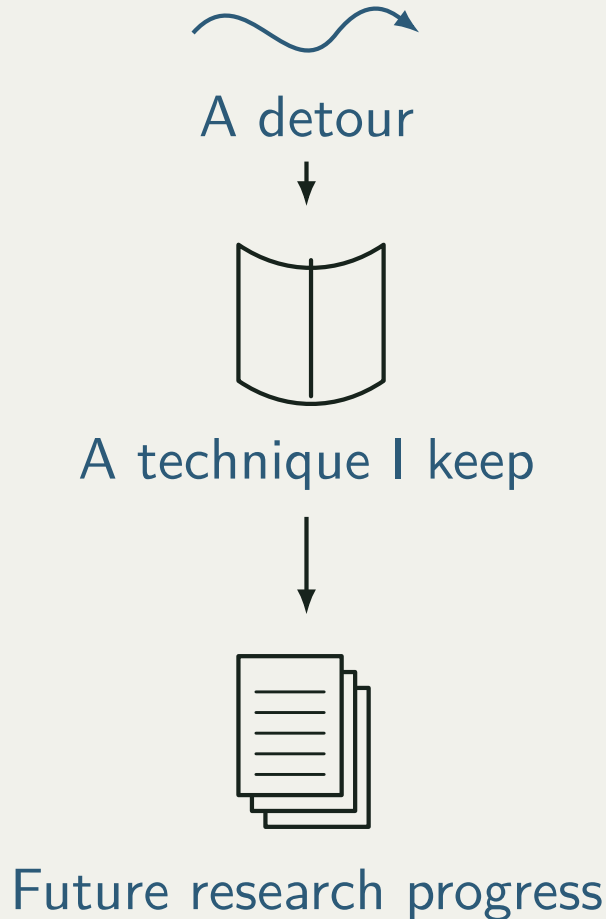
Advance a paper
already started



Learn something
I can use later

Each hour goes to one of them.

A detour can improve later research.



The technique becomes part of how I do research.

Longer detours leave less time for current projects.

A small detour



A longer detour



Research



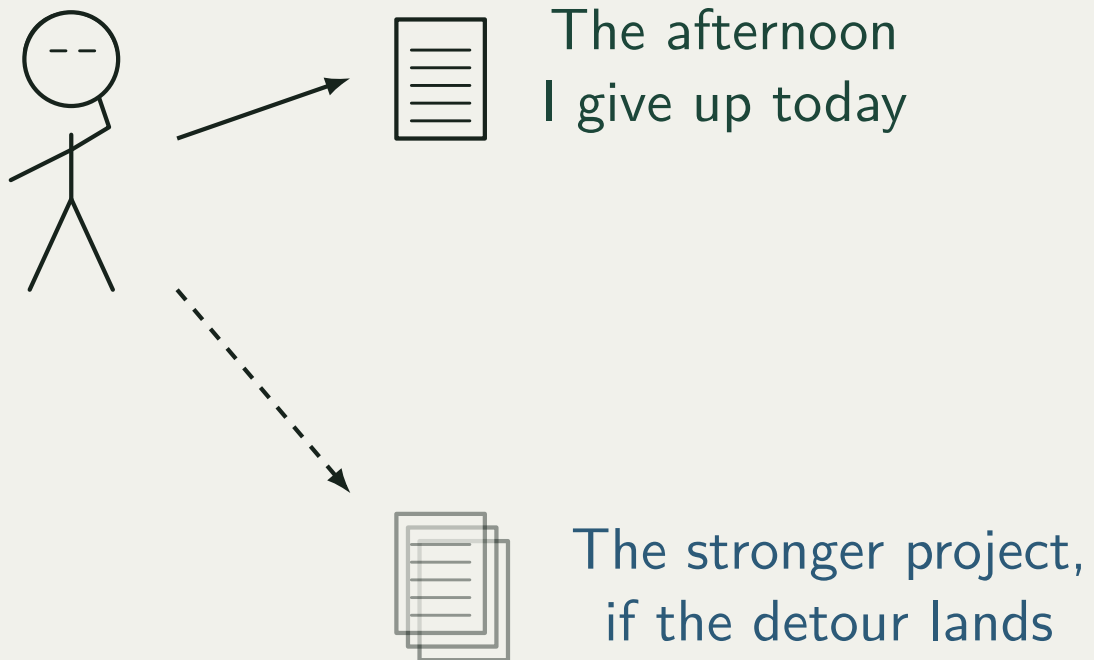
Exploration

The papers on my desk
still need to move forward.



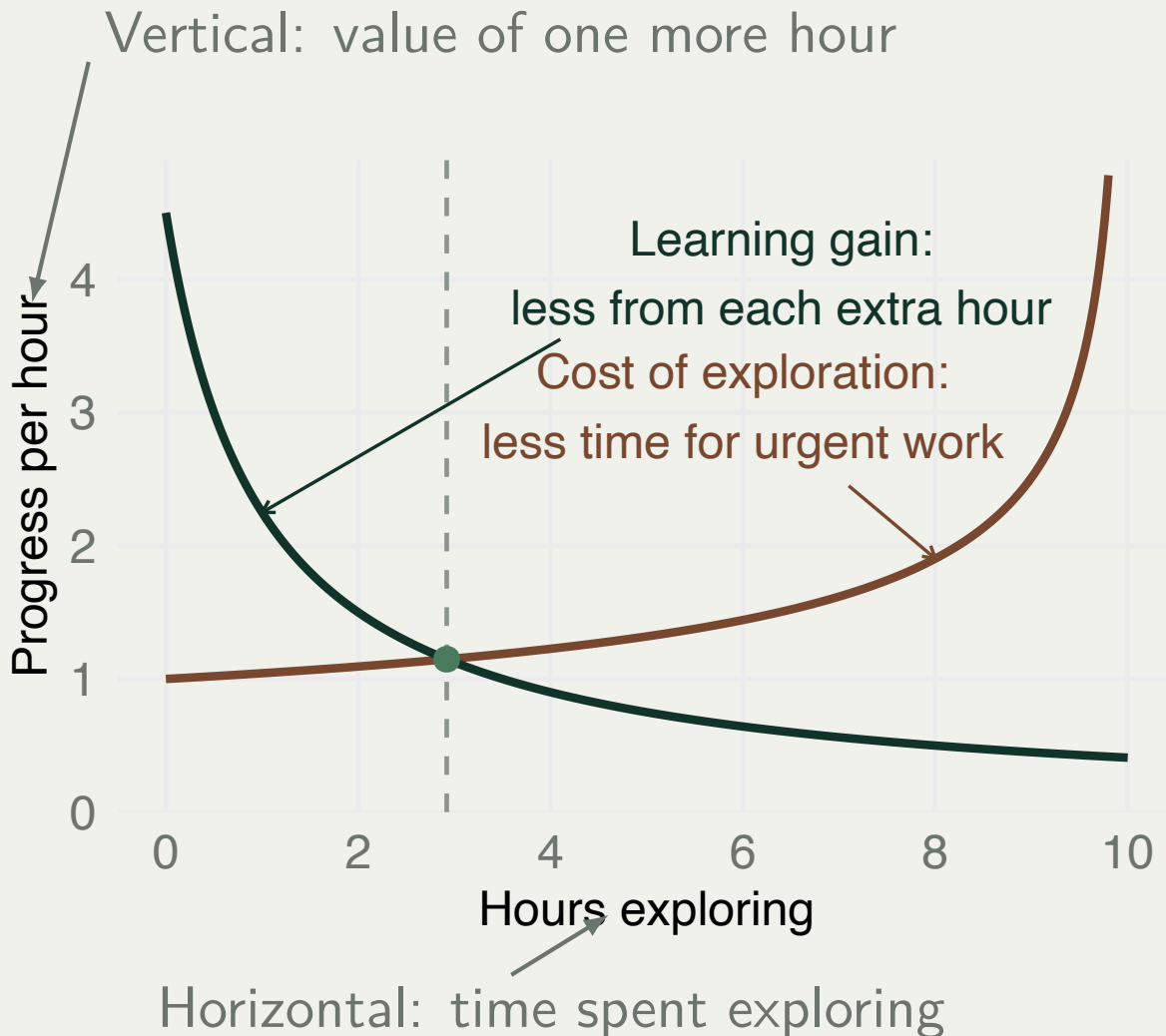
WHAT IF?

I know the cost of a digression, but only infer its value.



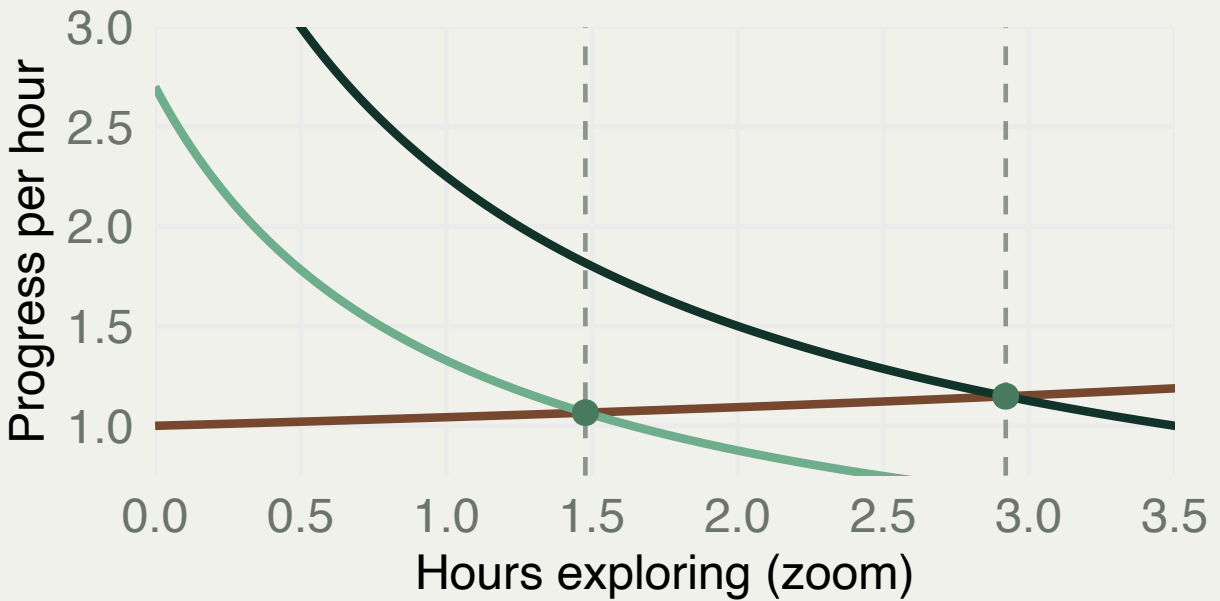
The cost is certain, the gain a chance. Putting the odds too low sets aside too little time.

I compare the next hour's cost and gain.

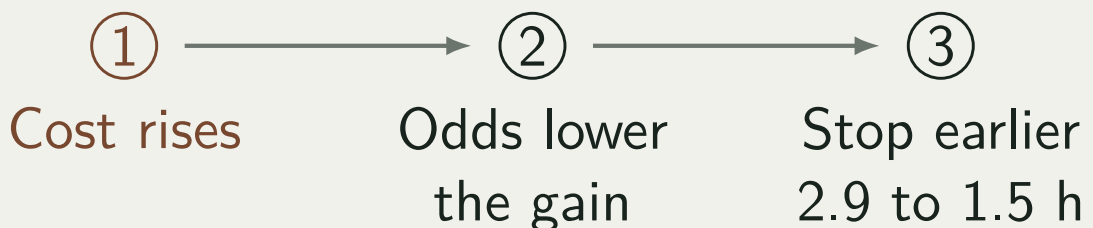


The curves meet at 2.9 hours.

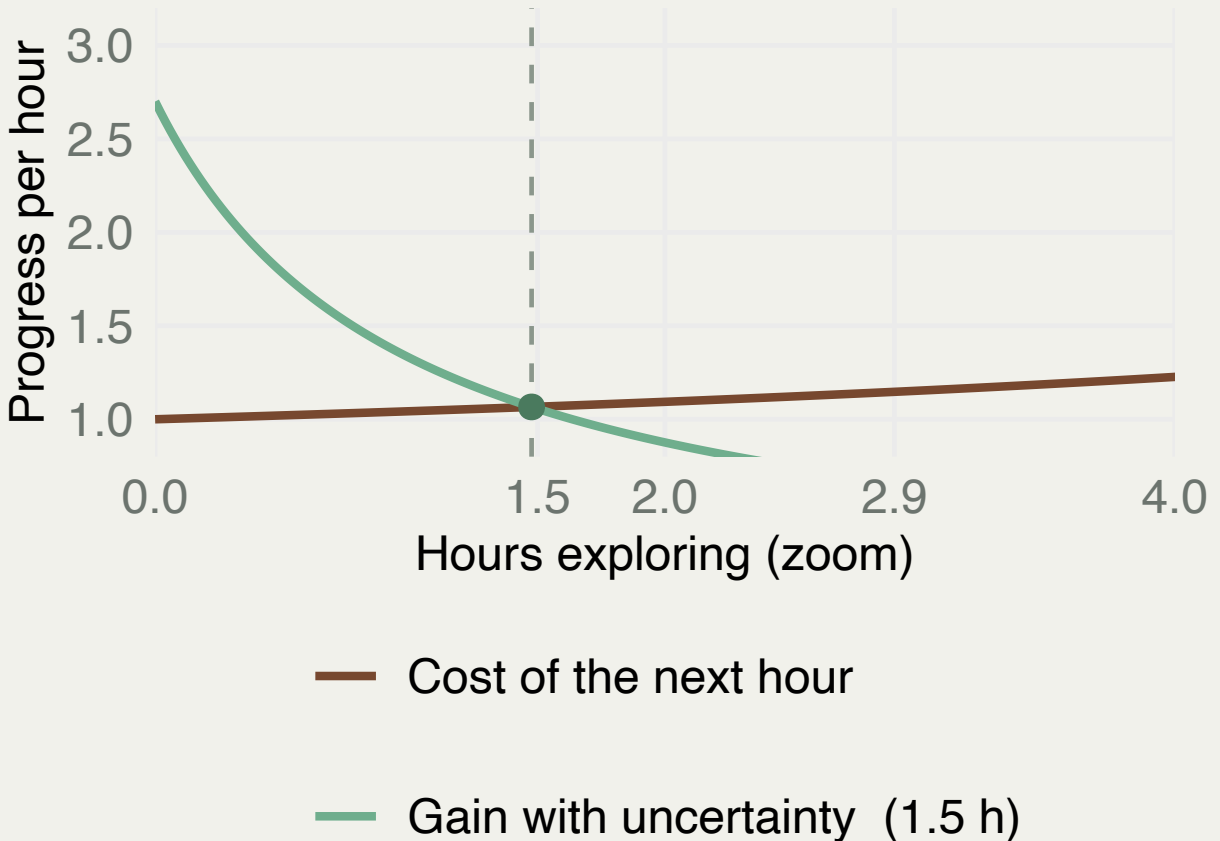
Uncertainty makes me stop earlier.



- Cost of the next hour
- Gain without uncertainty (2.9 h)
- Gain with uncertainty (1.5 h)

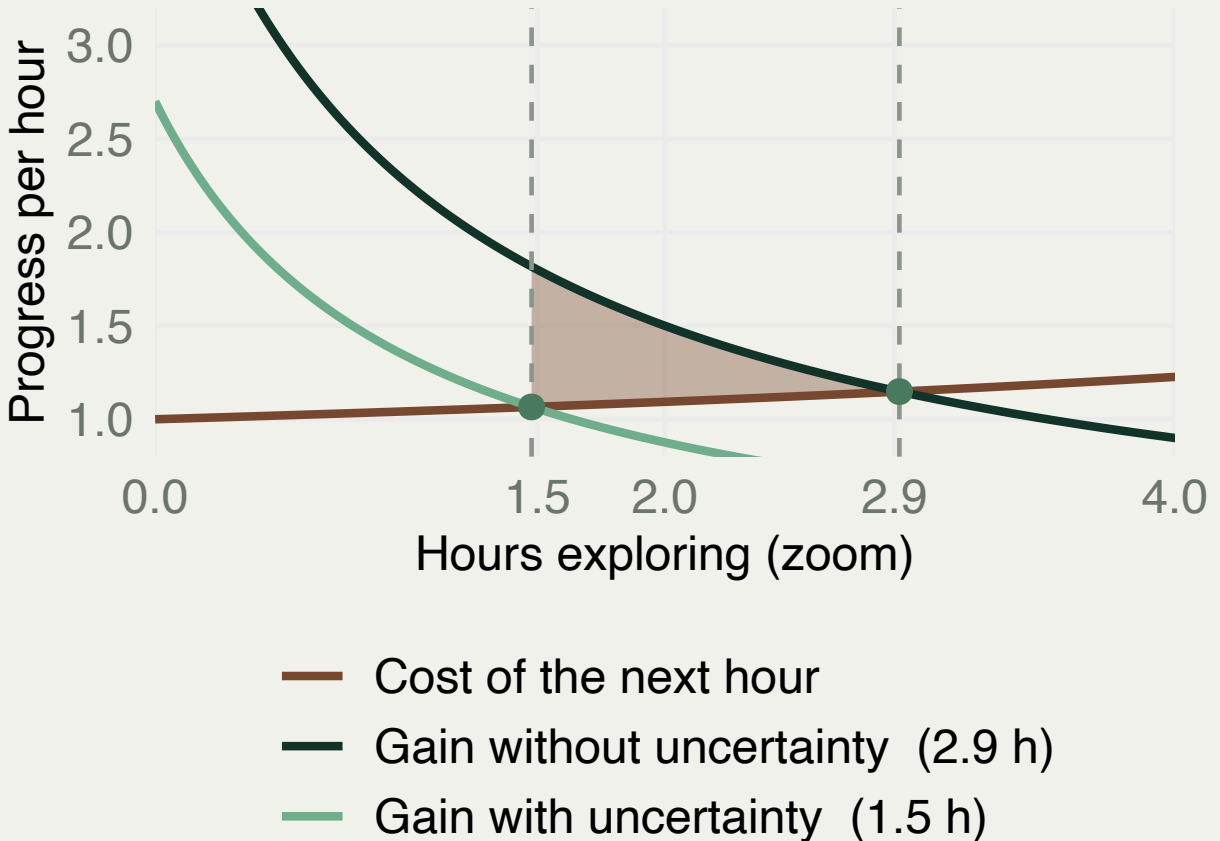


Uncertainty itself has a price.



1. Unsure the detour lands,
I stop after 1.5 hours.

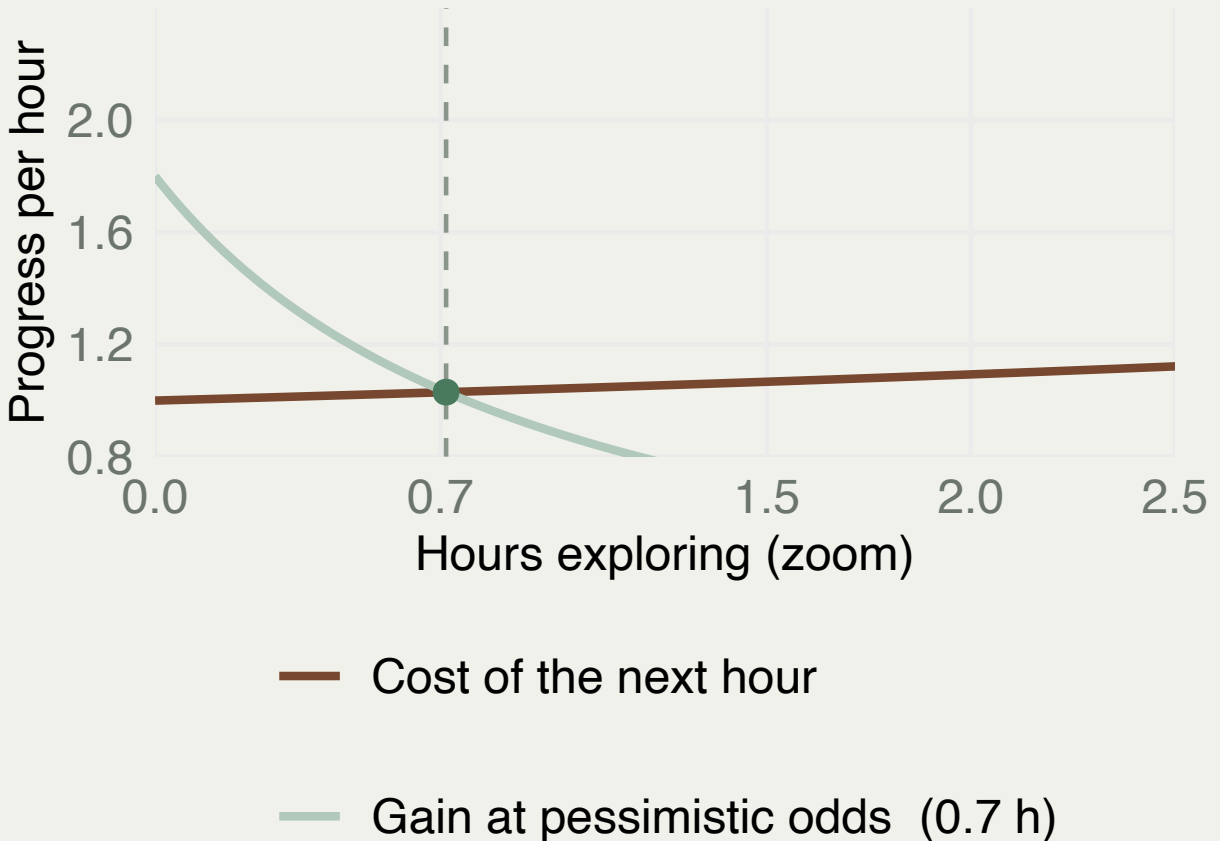
Uncertainty itself has a price.



2. Were it certain to land, those extra hours are worth about 25 minutes.

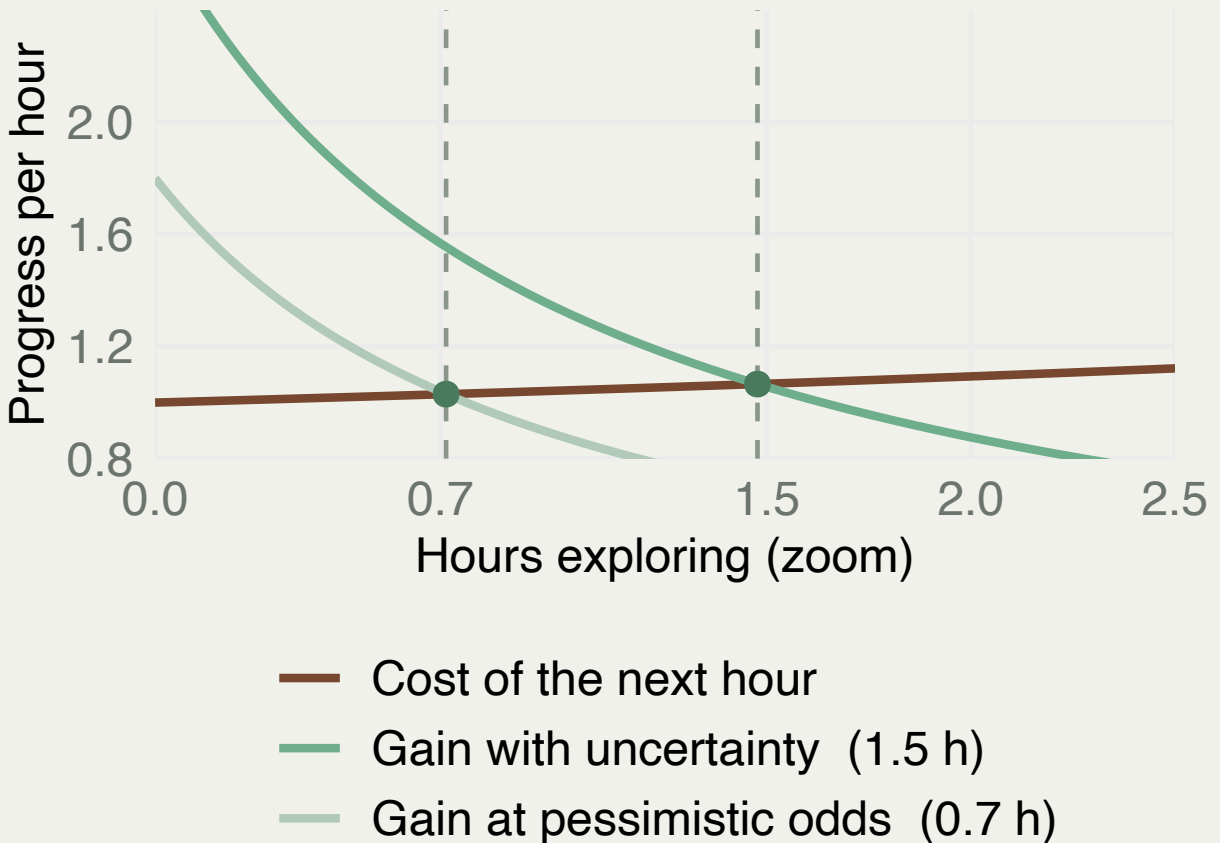
0.47 progress units. Stopping early is the right call here, not a mistake.

Believing procrastination useless costs even more.



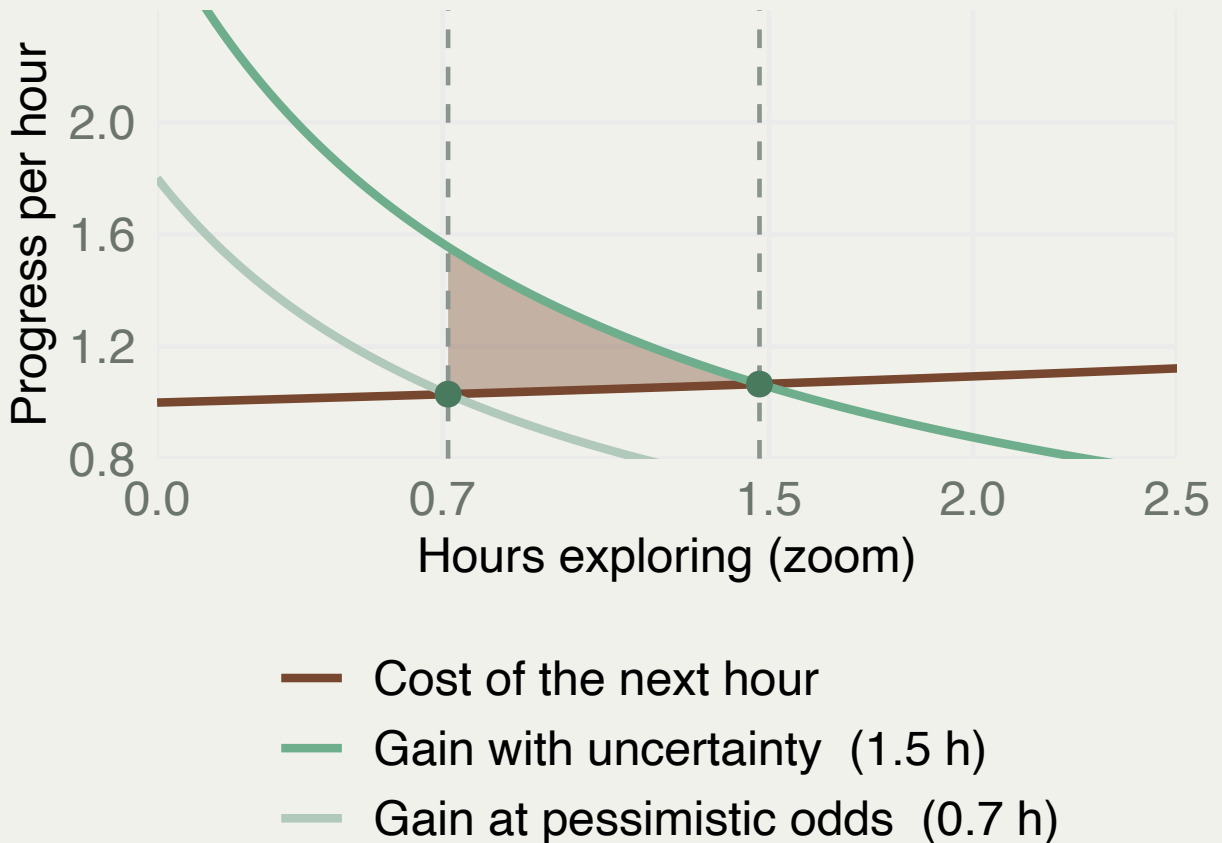
1. I assume 4-in-10 odds.
I stop after 0.7 hours.

Believing procrastination useless costs even more.



2. At 6-in-10 odds, I would explore 46 minutes longer.

Believing procrastination useless costs even more.



3. Net surplus: about 10 minutes of current research, in equivalent value.

0.18 risk-adjusted progress units; valued at marginal research cost.

A fair objection.

Am I justifying my
procrastination with
a toy model?



Possibly.
The hours still have to
go somewhere.

THE QUESTION I KEEP

Is digression progression?



Sometimes the long way round
reaches the better page.

I counted the hours both ways.
The arithmetic is in
the blog article.

pierrebeaucoral.github.io/post/time-to-learn/